channel, is a traditional type of harnessing rain water in the Cauvery delta. *Vati* is a drainage channel and a *vaykkal* is the supply channel. The commonly owned village channel was called *ur-vaykkal*. The nadu level vaykkal is referred to as *nadu-vaykkal*. The turn-system was in practice in distributing the water.

Religion

Chola rulers were ardent Saivites. Hymns, in praise of the deeds of Lord Siva, were composed by the Saiva saints, the Nayanmars. NambiyandarNambi codified them, which came to be known as the *Thirumurai*.

Temples

The Chola period witnessed an extensive construction of temples. The temples in Thanjavur, Gangaikonda Cholapuram and Darasuram are the repository of architecture, sculpture, paintings and iconography of the Chola art. Temples during the Chola period were not merely places of worship. They were the largest landholders. Temples promoted education, and devotional forms of art such as dance, music and drama. The staff of the temples included temple officials, dancing girls, musicians, singers, players of musical instruments and the priests.

Cholas as Patrons of Learning

Chola kings were great patrons of learning. Rajendra I established a Vedic college at Ennayiram (now in Villupuram District). There were 340 students learning the Vedas, grammar and Upanishads under 14 teachers. This example was later followed by his successors and as a result two more such colleges had been founded, at Tirubuvanai near present-day Puducherry and Tirumukkoodal in present-day Chengalpattu district, in 1048 and 1067 respectively. The great literary works *Periyapuranam and Kamba Ramayanam* belong to this period.

Trade

There was a flourishing trade during the Chola period. Trade was carried out by two guild-like groups: *anju-vannattar* and *mani-gramattar*. *Anju-vannattar* comprised West Asians, Arabs, Jews, Christians and Muslims. They were maritime traders and settled on the port towns all along the West Coast. It is said that *mani-gramattar* were the traders engaged in inland trade. In due course, both groups merged under the banner of *ai-nutruvar* and *disai-ayirattu-ai-nutruvar* functioning through the head guild in Ayyavole, Karnataka. This ai-nutruvar guild operated the maritime trade covering South-East Asian countries.



Big Temple Thanjavur



Gangaikonda Cholapuram Temple

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